Crimsonsoil Vernissage

Quest design document. I wrote this as a side quest for my own tabletop campaign and later reworked it for a single-player interactive version.

OVERVIEW

The players attend the opening of an art exhibition that turns out to be the artist's suicide note. The quest is a walk through four rooms of a rented mansion, and on the way in it looks like a strange but harmless evening. Everything the players look at closely on the way in becomes a threat on the way out, so the quest rewards curiosity first and then tests whether the players paid attention.

At the table it filled a session of a little over two hours, and as interactive fiction it takes about fifteen minutes.

PREMISE

Vissariel Amareio is one of the most famous artists of the elven realm, an elf of roughly six hundred years who vanished from the capital, Lethiris, ninety-six years ago without a trace. A week before the quest he reappears in the city of Verdmere, rents a mansion in the upper merchant quarter for two weeks and invites a small number of guests to a vernissage. Every ticket carries the same line: "Art that makes life seem precious."

The truth is that Amareio spent those ninety-six years as a prisoner of the Umbral elves, who live underground and keep slaves. They let him paint because they found his suffering decorative, and they released him once he stopped being interesting to them. The exhibition is his last work, and it ends with him killing himself in a ritual that summons six demons from his body.

BEFORE THE EXHIBITION

Players can go straight to the mansion, or spend the afternoon asking around. Asking around turns up two things. Nobody knows where Amareio has been, and the banker who handled the rent shows them the coins he was paid with: ordinary gold, very old coins with worn faces, and a few coins of dull violet metal stamped with the sigil of the Umbral elves. This is the first clue that his absence was not voluntary.

THE GUESTS

About twenty people attend, which keeps the rooms crowded enough that something can happen to a guest without the players being the only targets.

- Geoff, a friend of the players who got them the tickets
- Citricia Neifel, an elven noblewoman from a well-known family, with her human companion Torhan Jakornus and a bodyguard
- Fourteen dealers, critics and journalists (four humans, six elves, three half-elves and a gnome)
- Two priests of the Rose Mother, goddess of beauty and art, who are the first to understand what is happening at the end

THE ROOMS

Each room has one detail that careful players can find. At the table this was a Perception check, and in the interactive version it is a choice to look closer. Each room also has a consequence that triggers on the way back, and finding the detail on the way in is what lets players deal with it.

Entrance hall

Amareio greets the guests from the top of the stairs and promises them that nobody will leave the house the same person who entered it. The whole building is covered in loose, dark red earth, from the floorboards to the stairs, and nobody comments on it. A string quartet plays upstairs and gets louder as the evening goes on.

Room 1: abandoned places

The walls show paintings of abandoned places: a castle with a collapsed roof, wooden huts sinking into mud, and a dark cave with a barely visible body lying in it, reaching towards the light. Between the paintings stand sculptures of creatures with no faces and tangled limbs, including a figure with eight arms that all disappear into its own mouth.

The detail is a column built from small stones, each carved with an open mouth. Players who look closely (Perception DC 21 at the table) notice that the teeth are real. On the way back, the column comes apart into a Gravelmaw, a swarm of biting stones that blocks the exit. Players who try to leave early trigger it straight away.

Room 2: the weeping monument

A large stone statue of a kneeling woman with her face in her hands stands in the middle of the room. The paintings around it show glowing runes, torn flesh and a head with ten faces, and many smaller canvases show the same underground prison from different angles. Over the course of these paintings Amareio's signature degrades into tally marks.

The detail is a faint rustling from behind the statue's hands (Perception DC 18). On the way back, the statue lowers its hands, and a flickering spirit escapes from its blank face and attacks the guests. Players who heard the rustling know to keep away from the statue.

Room 3: the corridor of three

A narrow corridor holds three paintings, and all three react to the viewer.

The first shows a creature gnawing at a human body that is only a smear of paint. As the player watches, the body takes the shape of the player and shows their greatest flaw. On the way back, the creature, a Flawborn, steps out of the painting wearing the player's face and tempts them with exactly that flaw. Players who saw it earlier know what they are dealing with and can face it down.

The second shows a black crystal floating in a void. It pulls at anyone who looks at it too long. On the way back it traps a guest who walks past, and players who leaned in close earlier are its first target.

The third shows violet-skinned elves whipping a line of human prisoners, and the prisoner in front gets visibly more wounded while the players watch. On the way back, a whip reaches out of the canvas and drags Torhan towards the frame. Players who noticed the painting changing react fast enough to pull him free.

Room 4: the glass balcony

The last room has a large balcony enclosed in glass, with a huge self-portrait hanging below it. The portrait shows Amareio behind bars in a cell of dark earth. In the corner, a skeletal hand holds out a golden key just one finger's width beyond his reach.

Amareio gives a speech about how short life is and asks the guests whether anyone understood what his work was saying. Players who collected enough clues (the coins, the cave painting, the prison paintings, the whipping scene, the key) can answer that he was a prisoner. He confirms it: ninety-six years in the prisons of the Umbral elves, and a long search for the most horrifying subjects he could find, which ends with this exhibition.

Then he cuts his palm and lifts the knife to his throat.

THE ENDING

The ritual cannot be stopped completely, but players can disrupt it. A player who understood him can point out that he painted the key just out of reach instead of in his own hand, which means part of him still wants out. Alternatively, a player can rush the balcony and grab his arm, at the cost of getting cut. In both cases Amareio survives with a deep wound along his jaw and shoulder, and the six demons that emerge from the smoke of his blood are weakened. If nobody intervenes, he dies and the demons emerge at full strength.

Either way, the guests have to flee back through all four rooms, and every room now turns on them.

When I ran it, my players watched the ritual without intervening and then fled back through the exhibition, and all of them made it out.

DESIGN NOTES

The way back is the real quest. The first half is an exhibition where nothing seems to happen, and that only works if the second half pays it off. Every detail players find on the way in solves a problem on the way out, so careful players are rewarded and careless players are punished, but nobody is punished for something they had no chance to notice.

The horror comes out of the art. The paintings and sculptures should be described as genuinely beautiful and skilfully made before they become frightening. The gilded frames and the polite guests are there so that the contrast with what the art shows is uncomfortable.

The house gets darker room by room. Each room has less light than the one before, the music gets louder, and the earth on the floor gets deeper. In the interactive version the background colour darkens with each room and turns red on the way back.

Most of the story is in the rooms, not in dialogue. Amareio's backstory is told through his paintings, his coins and his self-portrait. His speech at the end only confirms what attentive players have already worked out, and players who missed the clues hear it as a riddle they can no longer solve.

CONTENT AND SAFETY

The quest contains body horror, torture, imprisonment and a suicide. My group had agreed on this kind of content in a session zero long before, and I know my players well, so the table needed no extra measures. The interactive version opens with a content note. Players can leave the house early at any point, which ends the quest without the climax.